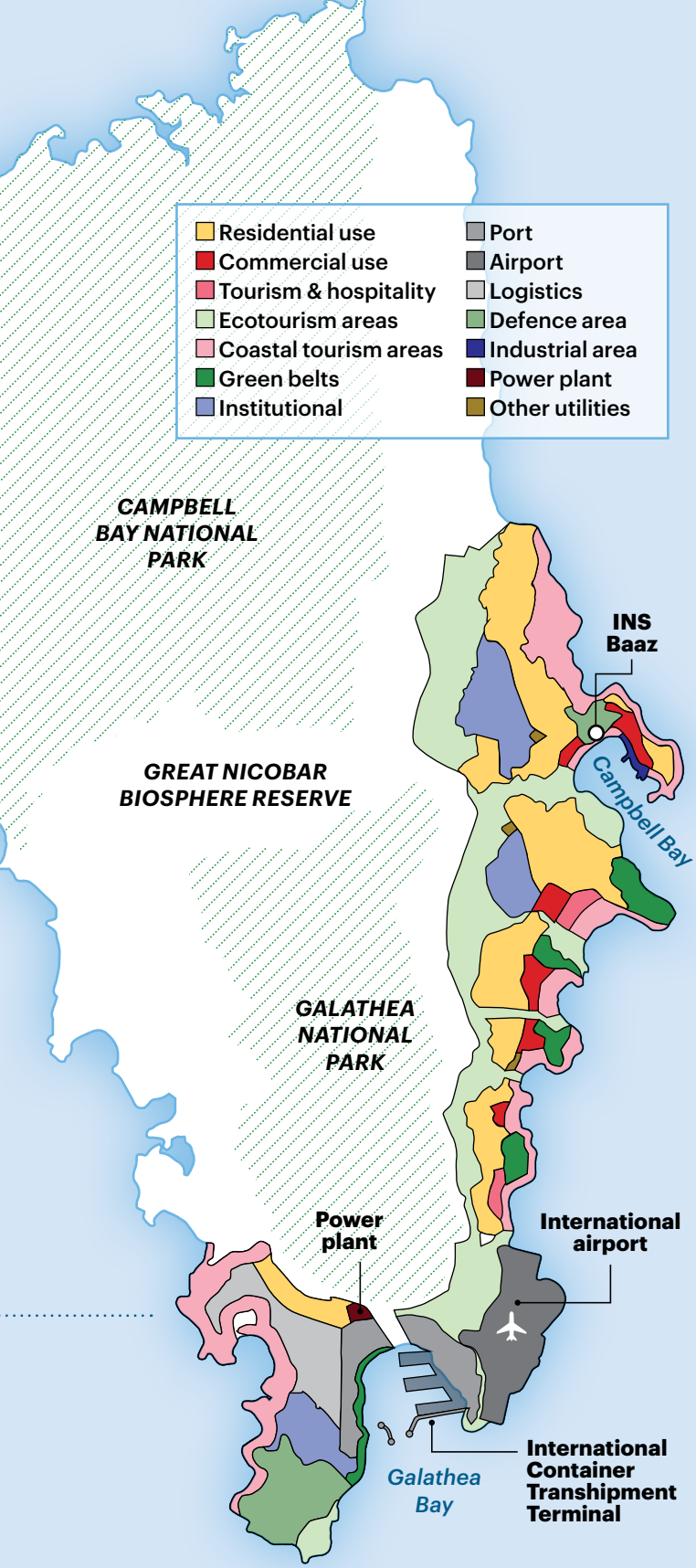


WHAT THE GOVERNMENT AIMS TO ACHIEVE

- Create an economic hub in the Indian Ocean Region
- Strengthen India's strategic presence in the region
- Promote sustainable and high-value tourism
- Generate socio-economic opportunities for local communities

FROM CONCEPTION TO CONTENTION

The Great Nicobar project so far...

JUN. 1, 2017
Islands Development Agency (IDA) constituted under the Union home minister to oversee development of islands

JAN. 13, 2020
IDA decides to pursue the 'Holistic Development of Great Nicobar Island' project

JANUARY 2021
NITI Aayog appoints a consultant to prepare a master plan; the draft outlines an International Container Transhipment Terminal, besides a greenfield township, airport and power plant

MARCH 2021
Andaman & Nicobar Islands Integrated Development Corporation (ANIIDCO) submits application to the environment ministry (MoEFCC), seeking Terms of Reference (ToR) for the project's environmental impact assessment

APRIL–MAY 2021
Expert Appraisal Committee (EAC) reviews proposal, issues detailed ToRs

JAN. 27, 2022
Public hearing held; has 138 participants, including tribals. Later, ANIIDCO seeks environmental clearance from the ministry

AUG. 22, 2022
EAC recommends for clearance after three meetings

OCT. 27, 2022
Stage-1 forest clearance (i.e. in-principle nod) granted for diverting 130.75 sq. km forest land

NOV. 11, 2022
Environmental and Coastal Regulation Zone clearances issued with multiple safeguard conditions covering ecology, pollution, tribal welfare and monitoring

DEC. 20, 2022
Environmentalist Ashish Kothari and others file multiple appeals against the project before the National Green Tribunal's (NGT's) Kolkata bench

APR. 3, 2023
NGT largely upholds environmental clearance but orders review of certain "unanswered deficiencies" by a High-Powered Committee (HPC)

APR. 13, 2023
HPC constituted under the MoEFCC secretary; it meets through mid-2023 and submits report stating that all "general and specific" environmental safeguards shall be complied with

2024-2025
The ministry files its affidavit, rejoinders before the tribunal

FEB. 16, 2026
NGT disposes of the matter, accepting the ministry's submissions on safeguards

Sources: MoEFCC and NITI Aayog